

get you talking. They use the “sympathetic” approach to try to get you to open up. Some will give a fake name, but they want you to “trust” them. They pretend to care about your problems and will listen to you. Be warned. The information you give them will be used against you.

Janice fell for this scheme. The collector oozed kindness and compassion on the phone. He asked questions that appeared innocent, and he seemed to have empathy with her struggles. He even told her how she reminded him of his own mother. Janice told him that she was working part-time as a waitress, trying to make ends meet. Now he knows the name of her employer and how much she makes because she volunteered the information.

Respect Yourself

Information is power. Do not give it to them. Attorney Richard DiMaggio states that, “The collector is not, and never will be, your friend... Tell the collector nothing. They do not care about you, and any question they ask should be ignored. You may owe a bill, but you owe the collector nothing – not even respect.”

Also, a word to the wise: Per the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act, collectors *have to* stop calling you on the phone once they’re *asked* to do so. After you do that, in accordance with the Act’s requirements, type up and mail them a brief letter that restates your “requests”: stop calling me at my home, stop calling me where I work.



Don't let
them mess
with your
self-respect!

Write It Down

Keeping track of all communication is important. The very first time you get a phone call about any alleged debt collection effort, write it down. Keep a simple notebook detailing the date, the time of the call, the name of the collection agent (whatever name they give you anyway), the name of their company, and what he or she said. Having a log is so much easier than trying to remember it later on, and if you do end up filing a complaint, your notebook will have all the information for you.